



THE TEN KEY ELEMENTS OF MINDFULNESS MEDITATION

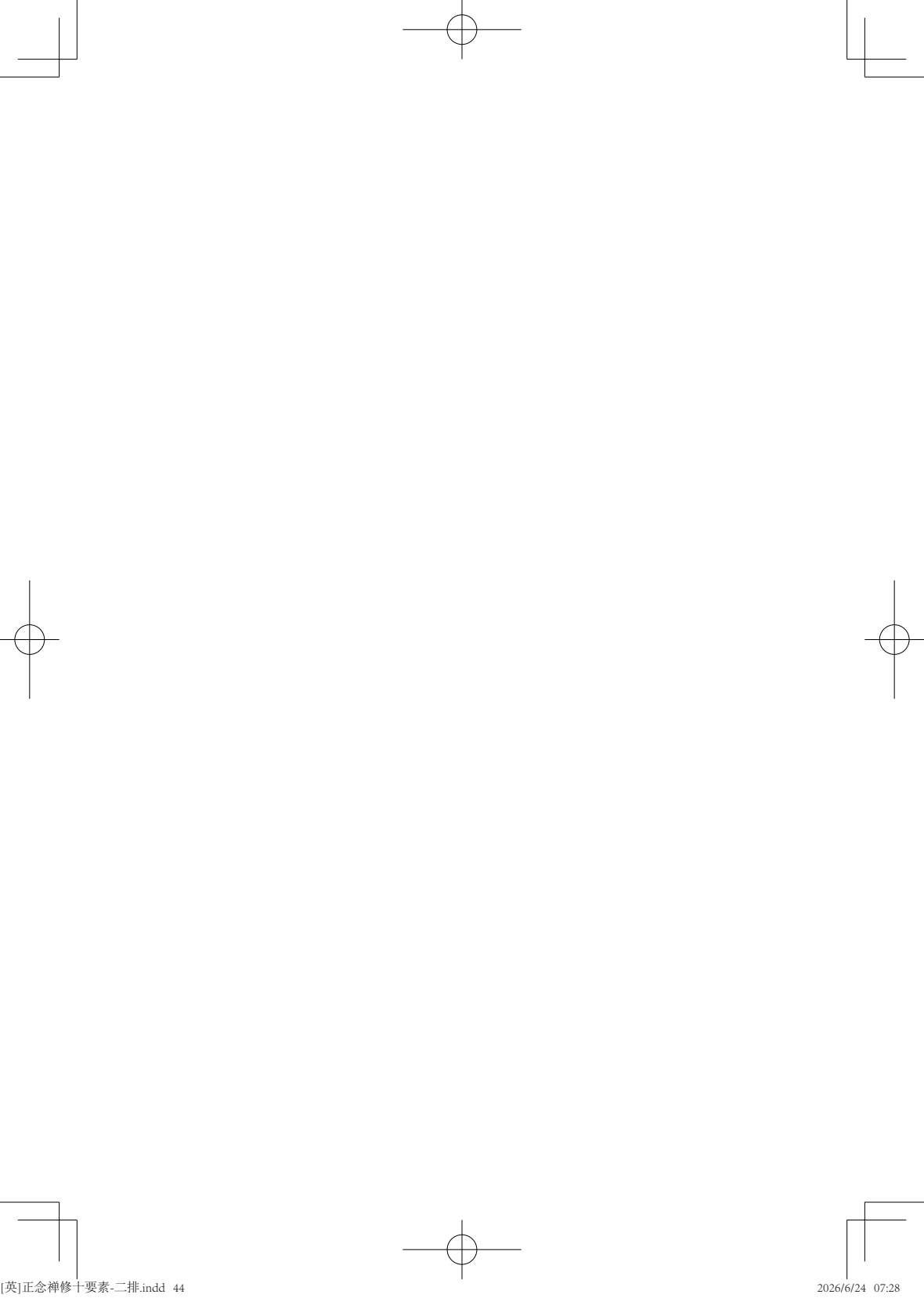
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Translated by MPI Translation Center

**A Teaching at the Great Meditation Hall in
Amrita Retreat Center in August 2024**

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The Dhyana Tea program team is now developing certification standards for beginner-level tea practitioners. The certification consists of technical skills and mental cultivation. Assessing technical skills is relatively straightforward, but assessing mental cultivation itself is not an easy task, as it is so abstract.

For mental cultivation, the hardest part is setting clear standards, so I thought of self-assessment. Mental cultivation can be self-assessed because the mind has self-knowing clarity. As a Buddhist saying goes, “Whether one has the Way or not, one knows for oneself,” because

practitioners generally do not deliberately deceive themselves. Of course, self-assessment is only one part of mental cultivation certification. Volunteer evaluators will also ask questions and provide opportunities for sharing and exchange.

Our entire practice system centers on three meditative qualities: the Eight Steps and Three Types of Meditation (the “Eight-Three Method”), Mindfulness Meditation, and Altruistic Meditation. These qualities form the core of the Dharma lineage and are essential for all overseas Mindful Peace Ambassadors, especially for Class Facilitators. Therefore, developing self-assessment standards for Mindfulness Meditation has become a shared need in nurturing mental cultivation among overseas Class Facilitators and Mindful Peace Ambassadors.

Mindfulness Meditation consists of three levels, where the beginner and intermediate levels share ten elements. Among them, the three basic elements are aspiration, a simple and orderly life, and enthusiasm; the three

Samatha elements are an object of focus, attention, and concentration; and the four Vipassana elements are awareness, acceptance, non-judgment, and right view. Across the various Mindfulness Meditation programs we offer, these ten elements form the focus of our training and serve as key criteria for evaluation.

The mental cultivation certification is not simply about obtaining a certificate. It is an opportunity to understand ourselves, to learn from and share with others, and, more importantly, to deepen our inner cultivation. By taking part in the certification, we can clearly see the current state of our cultivation in the ten elements: where our training is weak, where it is strong, and where it can still be improved. Therefore, for the mental cultivation certification, we not only need to accurately understand the Ten Key Elements, but also learn how to practice each one. Over the past two days, I've given this some thought. Today, I'd like to share it with everyone.

I

THREE BASIC ELEMENTS

1. The First Element: Aspiration

Aspiration has two aspects. First, do we understand the benefits of mindfulness and why we practice it? Second, how confident are we in the value it brings?

What is the value of right mindfulness, and why has it become so popular worldwide? Simply put, it offers both practical and ultimate benefits.

People often practice right mindfulness because of its practical benefits, such as reducing stress and pain,

enhancing concentration, treating mental health issues, sparking creativity, and improving physical and mental health. Our mindfulness body scan also has these effects.

However, right mindfulness, as taught by the Buddha, is one factor of the Noble Eightfold Path and leads to the ultimate benefit—liberation from samsara, and to life's awakening. The core value of right mindfulness is to cultivate awareness, for awareness is the key to the awakened nature and the best way to attain awakening. We can say that right mindfulness is the most direct and accessible path to awakening that the Buddha offered for all beings. Through this practice, we can not only awaken ourselves but also, for Mahayana practitioners, help others move toward awakening. Thus, any practical benefits that come are simply by-products of the practice.

So when we cultivate right mindfulness, we should ask ourselves: Why am I practicing it? Let us examine our aspirations.

If we practice for practical benefits, our aspiration is wholesome but remains on the worldly level. If our aspiration is solely to attain our own awakening and liberation, this is the mind of renunciation—the aspiration of the Sravakayana, or the path of personal liberation. But if our aspiration is to guide countless beings toward awakening and liberation through right mindfulness, this is bodhicitta—the aspiration of the Mahayana Bodhisattva Path. Each time we examine our aspiration, we clarify the motivation, goal, and direction of our mindfulness practice.

Having recognized the value of right mindfulness, we should further ask ourselves: Do we have strong confidence in it?

In meditation, confidence is especially important. Without confidence, our aspiration has no strength. Just as the *Yogacarabhumi-Sastra* teaches, aspiration is characterized by “seeking”—a mind that earnestly seeks to attain something. It is a kind of “desire,” just like a person who

wishes to buy a car or a house, or to start a family and build a career. Actually, Buddhism teaches that desire is of three kinds: wholesome, neutral, and unwholesome. The wish to attain physical and mental well-being through right mindfulness, or to realize awakening and liberation, is also a kind of desire. Yet this is a wholesome desire—a wish for goodness. In addition to wholesome desire, there are also unwholesome and neutral forms of desire. Neutral desire does not involve good or evil, while unwholesome desire is connected with harmful actions. Clearly, the more confident we are that mindfulness practice can lead to these wholesome results, the stronger our aspiration becomes.

In practicing right mindfulness, we should understand our aspiration as it truly is and adjust it according to the Dharma.

2. The Second Element: A Simple and Orderly Life

A simple and orderly life means living with simplicity,

modesty, order, and morality.

Many people think that meditation is merely a method for training the mind, so what does it have to do with daily life?

In essence, Buddhist practice comes down to the cultivation of precepts, concentration, and wisdom—also known as the Threefold Training that transcends defilements, leading to awakening and liberation. From precepts arises concentration, and from concentration arises wisdom, revealing how they are connected. Among these, precepts show that, in our practice, we need to live a healthy life—one that is simple, modest, orderly, and moral.

Our thoughts flow continuously, each one similar to the last, shaped by our daily life and actions. For ordinary people, the mind is easily swayed by external conditions; when daily life is chaotic, the mind inevitably becomes chaotic. The *Agama Sutra* teaches, “When precepts are pure, the mind is pure.” Only when life off the cushion is

simple and plain can the mind more easily grow calm and clear on the cushion. If, during meditation, we remain caught in worries and entanglements, unable to stop wandering thoughts or let go of love and hate, unable even to sit steadily, how can we practice well?

An orderly life is also important. A defining feature of modern people is that they live in chaos and disorder. They spend much of their time on meaningless things, wasting their lives and losing control of themselves. Therefore, to manage the mind, we should begin by managing daily life. It is best to set a regular schedule and build a simple, orderly life.

Precepts allow us to be free from regret. When we observe the precepts, we keep our actions free from fault and avoid regret. Free from regret, we can live with ease—just as the saying goes, “The noble man is always broad-minded and at ease.”

When the precepts are pure, life becomes pure; when life

is pure, the mind grows pure; and when the mind is pure, meditation naturally deepens. Therefore, by observing precepts and living a simple, modest, moral and orderly life, we create an essential prerequisite for mindfulness meditation.

3. The Third Element: Enthusiasm

Enthusiasm means being genuinely passionate about mindfulness meditation.

Are we truly enthusiastic about meditation? Do we merely treat it as a routine and go through the motions, or do we genuinely enjoy it—and the Dharma joy it brings—as it purifies our mind with each session? Meditation will be very difficult without the right method and proper use of the mind.

Of course, enthusiasm does not come out of nowhere; it needs its own causes and conditions. How can we maintain our enthusiasm for meditation for a long period of

time? First, we need to understand the true meaning of meditation.

If we see someone around us maintain a consistent meditation practice and change noticeably—similar to what Christianity calls a testimony—our enthusiasm for practice naturally grows. While Christian testimony speaks of the grace, miracles, and glory given by God, Buddhist “testimony” points to the transformation arising from within through practicing the Dharma. This transformation shows up directly in improved views, mindsets, and quality of life, and indirectly in better relationships and the healing of physical and mental conditions. These real-life examples are role models that help us build confidence, enthusiasm, and motivation for meditation.

Second, we must learn the right way to use the mind.

When we first start meditating, we are often filled with confidence and joy. Yet if we do not understand the proper way to cultivate the mind, our efforts may be

in vain—or even lead us in the opposite direction. The more diligently we practice, the more confused we may feel. When we lack the right method or gain no benefit even after a long time, we find it difficult to tell how far our practice has progressed. As confidence fades, we find it harder to continue the path. Meditation is like finding our way through a complex maze of the mind—it requires the right method, the guidance of a wise teacher, and a clear understanding of what the practice can truly bring.

We often misunderstand the Buddhist teaching of “nothing to attain,” thinking that it means practice is not about results. In fact, “nothing to attain” does not mean there are no results. Rather, it means even when results arise, we do not cling to them. More importantly, Buddhism teaches the law of cause and effect—“As the cause, so is the result.” When our method is right, the corresponding result will certainly follow. This principle applies to everyone. Anyone can learn meditation and experience its results through their own practice. Moreover, “nothing to attain” also refers to the realization of emptiness, which

transcends the subject and object to attain the wisdom that is free from grasping.

Therefore, we should often ask ourselves: Is my method of meditation correct? The Three Levels of Mindfulness Meditation we advocate use a method that is simple, applicable, and easy to practice. As long as we keep using the right method every time, the right results will naturally follow.

Third, we must practice repeatedly.

Once we have learned the right method, we need to keep repeating it. On the one hand, practice helps us break free from habits built up since beginningless time; on the other, it helps us develop concentration and awareness, and transform the mental habits that keep us in samsara. If a simple, orderly lifestyle represents a change in the way we live, then cultivating mindfulness represents a change in the way we use the mind. Whether we are letting go of old habits or building new ones, both

require ongoing repetition and sufficient training. This is how every mental pattern is formed, and cultivating a new way of using the mind is no exception. Only through repeated practice can we become increasingly familiar with mindfulness, and only through such familiarity can the power of mindfulness gradually grow. In this way, we can continually experience the joy of meditation and the happiness that comes from inner transformation.

Effective meditation requires a proper method. First, we must focus on quality. Many people think the longer they meditate, the better. They insist on sitting for a fixed length of time each day—half an hour, an hour, two hours, even three—and keep increasing it. As a result, the longer they sit, the more uncomfortable they feel, and some even grow afraid of sitting. In fact, what matters most in meditation is quality. Once quality is assured, quantity can be increased.

Especially for beginners, meditation should be like a patient eating small, frequent meals. In the beginning,

each session can be short—five or ten minutes are fine. What matters is that these five or ten minutes are of good quality, rather than sitting for an hour when fifty minutes are wasted. Nor should we wait until we can no longer sit before ending the session. It is better to stop while a sense of enjoyment still remains. On the basis of quality, we can arrange more sittings each day and gradually build a good habit. It is best to make a timetable, set aside fixed times for meditation, decide how many sittings to do each day and how long each should be, and then gradually increase the length.

On the other hand, we should extend mindfulness into daily life in a planned way, allowing it to gradually fill every part of our lives. We encourage bringing mindfulness into daily life. But it is unrealistic to expect ourselves to stay mindful for twenty-four hours every day. Therefore, to start, it is better to choose two or three simple daily tasks and practice mindfulness while doing them. As the strength of mindfulness grows, we can gradually extend it to other areas of life, until, in the end,

mindfulness becomes present in every moment.

Why could the great masters of the past fully integrate meditation into their daily lives? Because their lives were simple—fetching firewood, carrying water, getting dressed, and eating their meals. As their practice deepened, some great teachers would later go out into the world to cultivate their minds with challenges. Today, however, we live much busier and more restless lives; the conditions for practice are far more challenging than in the past. To maintain enthusiasm for meditation, we truly need supportive conditions and skillful means.

II

THE THREE KEY ELEMENTS OF SAMATHA

The three elements discussed earlier are the foundational elements of mindfulness meditation. After that, we move into the practice of samatha and vipassana meditations. Samatha contains three essential elements, while vipassana contains four.

1. The Fourth Element: An Object of Focus

In the beginner stage of mindfulness meditation, we need to choose an object of focus. This focus helps the mind overcome dullness and distraction during practice.

Distraction is often mentioned together with restlessness. Although the *Treatise on the Hundred Dharmas* classifies them as two distinct mental factors, restlessness can also be seen as a form of distraction. The difference lies in this: distraction causes the mind to wander in all directions—it jumps from one thought to another without settling anywhere, while restlessness is marked by agitation and mental excitement.

Restlessness is called *diaoju* in Chinese. *Diao* means “to sway,” referring to an unsettled mind, while *ju* means “to lift,” describing a mind that is stirred up and unable to calm down. For example, when we think of something exciting, see someone we have not seen for a long time, or receive good news, our mind easily becomes excited and filled with wandering thoughts—this is restlessness.

Dullness refers to the mind that becomes dim and unclear, as if falling asleep. Of course, sleep is more severe than dullness, for in sleep, awareness is completely lost, while in mild dullness some clarity remains. In short, dullness

is when the mind loses its clarity and can no longer see things clearly.

Overcoming dullness and restlessness in meditation is challenging because they have become our habits. Our mind is used to wandering all day long. How can we change these habits? The *Ox-Herding Pictures* offer an analogy: to prevent the ox from running wild, we must tie it firmly to a post with a rope, keeping it in place. In mindfulness meditation, an object of focus serves as that “post”—an anchor that prevents the mind from wandering. This is how we cultivate concentration.

We need to choose our object of focus carefully. Although we often encourage integrating mindfulness into every moment and turning life itself into a form of meditation, this is not easy to do at any time or place. Especially in the beginning, when we can still be easily influenced by the many things we encounter, we need to select a wholesome object as an anchor. A wholesome object is one that supports meditation—something effective and conducive

to mental stability. It should not cause strong likes or dislikes. That is why we choose neutral objects such as the breath or steps. They are simple, part of daily life, always available, and not likely to cause clinging—after all, few people become attached to their breath or their steps. Choosing such an object helps the mind develop concentration in meditation.

So is it necessary to have an object of focus in meditation? Can we practice without one? This depends on the stage of practice and its need. In the beginner stage, we need a fixed object of focus. Then, in the intermediate stage, the focal object no longer needs to stay fixed. Finally, in the advanced stage, we no longer need a focal object as we directly experience the true nature of mind and abide in it.

Thus, Three-Stage Mindfulness Meditation unfolds as follows: from mindfulness meditation to no-thought meditation; from having an object of focus to being free from one; from engaging with an object to letting it go;

from relying on an anchor to being without one. Whether it is Dhyana Tea or any other forms of mindfulness practice, in the beginner stage, it is essential to choose an object of focus and find an anchor.

2. The Fifth Element: Attention

What kind of mental factor is “attention”? Why is it essential among the ten elements of mindfulness meditation?

The *Treatise on the Hundred Dharmas* explains each mental factor in terms of its feature and its function. For “attention,” its feature is alertness, and its function is to direct the mind toward its object. “Alertness” is its essence, as it helps the mind remain alert. “Directing the mind toward its object” means that this alert state guides the mind toward its intended object.

In daily life, we are not always alert. For example, when we become lost in wandering thoughts, alertness is absent. But in certain situations, such as walking along a steep

path or entering an area where snakes might appear, we instinctively become highly alert and stop letting the mind wander. This shows that alertness helps to uplift the mind, and prevents it from drifting, allowing concentration to arise easily. With alertness as the foundation, we can clearly see whether there are snakes underfoot and stay focused on each step we take. Without attention, we walk carelessly, unaware of what we might be stepping on.

When we understand the feature and function of attention, we realize that we need to make especially good use of it in meditation. There are two main purposes for this. First, attention helps to overcome distraction, because when the mind is highly alert, it does not fall into a scattered state.

I once guided a meditation where participants imagined themselves meditating atop a 200-meter-high pillar. Would you still dare to doze off, indulge in wandering thoughts, or let your mind become distracted or restless? In that moment, you would naturally become highly

alert. When we meditate with such high alertness, the mind is far less likely to fall into distraction.

At the same time, alertness also makes it easier to cultivate concentration. For example, when we take walking or breathing as an anchor, attention allows us to direct the mind toward it. Yet our capacity for concentration is limited. After maintaining focus for a while, the mind will gradually drift away. When this happens, we need to reawaken alertness and bring the mind back to the anchor. Each time the mind wanders into distraction, we use alertness to bring it back again. The practice of *samatha* is simply training the mind in this way.

With alertness and awareness, we can recognize when the mind drifts away; without them, we would not notice at all. The stronger our awareness, the more quickly we can notice when the mind begins to wander. Without training, however, we might spend days lost in delusive thoughts without even realizing what we are doing.

This shows that attention helps to free the mind from distraction.

On the other hand, attention helps free the mind from dullness. Since attention includes alertness, as soon as we become alert, we can emerge from dullness and break free from a state of mental obscurity. This is because alertness is connected to awareness; alertness is one function of awareness. Through attention, we can overcome dullness and continue bringing the mind back to the object.

In the practice of samatha, both an object of focus and attention are essential supportive conditions. Once we have chosen an object to focus on, we must continually rely on the power of attention to free the mind from distraction and dullness, bringing it back to the focal point again and again. This is how we develop concentration.

Some may ask, “Must we use attention in meditation?”

In the Three-Stage Mindfulness Meditation, beginners

must use attention, because at this stage we need to choose an external anchor and focus on it by using attention.

In the intermediate stage of meditation, we focus on expanding awareness, for the objects of focus are constantly changing. At one moment we may be walking, at another eating, and later talking with others. When facing these ever-changing objects, we need a steadier power of awareness. This means we must train awareness in daily life—eating with awareness, walking with awareness, and doing everything with awareness.

Awareness is closely related to alertness. In the intermediate stage of meditation, we must make good use of alertness that comes from attention, so that we can maintain awareness at any time and in any place. Whenever we lose awareness, we use alertness to bring it back. When our mind becomes scattered or carried away by thoughts, we rely on alertness once again to restore awareness. Just as in the beginner stage, we also need to use attention in intermediate mindfulness practice. The difference is that

in the intermediate stage of meditation, we place greater emphasis on using alertness to support and expand awareness, and we no longer need to stay with a fixed object of focus.

In the advanced mindfulness meditation, we let go of both alertness and awareness—there is no need for attention or any object of focus. The purpose at this stage is to directly experience our true mind—inherently complete and clear. This clear mind is ever present. All we need to do is simply experience it, recognize it, and gradually become familiar with it.

The clear mind is not an object, so experiencing it requires no mental effort. It also does not have a point to focus on, so alertness is not needed. In fact, bringing up alertness will take us back to the previous level of conscious cognition. Therefore, in advanced meditation, we must let go of attention and all focal points in order to experience this clear, uncontrived mind.

In short, meditation can be divided into two types: contrived and uncontrived. Contrived meditation must use attention. However, to practice uncontrived meditation, we must learn to let go of deliberate attention and all mental efforts—only then can we truly experience the original mind.

3. The Sixth Element: Concentration

In the MPI meditation framework, mindfulness practice focuses on cultivating two abilities: concentration and awareness. The five elements discussed earlier provide the foundation and skillful means for developing concentration. The purpose of training concentration is to settle the mind on a single object. That is why the practice of samatha is also called abiding meditation.

To keep the mind steadily focused on a single object, we need specific methods. The object of focus and deliberate attention, as discussed earlier, are important supports for developing concentration. In addition, it is also important

to cultivate a wholesome inner environment.

The sutras teach that to cultivate samatha, we must first curb the five sensual desires and eliminate the five hindrances. The five sensual desires generally refer to sight, sound, smell, taste, and tangible object—the sense objects pursued by the five sense faculties. The five sensual desires can also be understood as the desires for wealth, sexual pleasure, fame, food, and drowsiness.

To curb the five desires is to reduce how the mind drives the senses to crave external objects. If we habitually follow craving, the mind will constantly seek pleasing sights, sounds, tastes, or become preoccupied with wealth, sexual pleasure, fame, food, and drowsiness. As a result, our mind cannot remain calm, and distractions easily arise.

The five hindrances are five types of affliction that obscure the clarity of the mind: desire, aversion, dullness (including sleeping), restlessness (including remorse), and

doubt. Strong desire leaves no room for spiritual practice; aversion agitates the mind and makes it restless; dullness gives no rise to alertness; restlessness disturbs inner peace; and unresolved doubt leads to disbelief in the Three Jewels and the methods of practice. Clearly, all of these are major obstacles to meditation. Therefore, by curbing the five desires and eliminating the five hindrances, we establish a wholesome inner environment that allows the practice of samatha to unfold more smoothly and effectively.

Since this is samatha practice, where exactly should the mind rest? In fact, samatha meditation has three levels.

At the first level—the beginner stage, we select an external object as the focus. Since we aim to train concentration and unlock awareness, we rest the mind on that external object of focus.

At the second level—the intermediate stage—focusing the mind on a single point is no longer the purpose. Instead,

the key is to abide in awareness itself. In the beginner stage, we choose an anchor for the mind, but this is just a skillful means. Like tying a cow to a post, the post itself is not important—what matters is that the cow does not wander off. Mindfulness practice begins with beginner meditation, which helps us access awareness. From there, we learn to extend awareness, abide in it, and carry it into every moment of daily life. Awareness, therefore, lies at the heart of mindfulness meditation throughout the entire practice. At the intermediate stage, the focus is on extending awareness, allowing the mind to rest in awareness itself.

At the third level—the advanced stage, the goal is to abide in the original mind, the inherently complete, uncontrived mind; it is infinitely vast and clear. The Chan school directly points to the true mind, helping practitioners realize their Buddha-nature and return to the original mind—the mind that is clear and inherently complete.

These three levels follow a progressive path. The first level supports the second, and the second supports the third. We need to understand that meditation is a continual process of cultivating and letting go. And each time we cultivate and let go, we clear away the restless, deluded mind, helping us transcend consciousness, and ultimately return to the inherently clear mind. Thus, the Three-Stage Mindfulness Meditation offers a complete path of practice through three levels of samatha. It presents a progressive path of practice—from mindfulness meditation to no-thought meditation—outlining a complete journey that progresses from the beginning to the advanced stages, and from gradual cultivation to sudden awakening.

Training concentration is to cultivate samatha; and cultivating samatha is to develop samadhi. Samadhi means that the mind can settle on its chosen object very steadily. Both Mahayana and Theravada teachings talk about the nine stages of samatha: placement of the mind, continuous placement, repeated placement, close placement,

taming the mind, pacifying the mind, and fully pacifying the mind, single-pointing, and balanced placement. These nine stages describe a step-by-step deepening of samatha. In the MPI system, it is not necessary to reach the ninth stage of samatha. Attaining the seventh stage, along with the seven stages of vipassana meditation, is sufficient to complete the training in meditation.

Different Buddhist schools hold different views on the relationship between samatha and vipassana. Even within Theravada Buddhism, there are different approaches to samadhi. The Pa-Auk system sets particularly high requirements for samatha, even to the point of attaining the Four Dhyanas and Eight Samadhis, while the Mahasi Sayadaw and Ajahn Chan approaches do not impose such high requirements on samatha.

For people today, cultivating samatha is very difficult, because samadhi arises through causes and conditions—it requires intentional cultivation. Only through dedicated practice can the mind, used to wandering freely, become

settled.

In the past, monastics lived in the mountains and led very simple lives, so cultivating samatha was easier. In contrast, people today live disordered lives, making it very difficult to cultivate samadhi. Therefore, in the Mahasi system, samatha and vipassana are trained together—cultivating concentration while developing awareness. Chan Buddhism goes even further. Its teachings say: “We speak only of seeing one’s true nature, not of meditative concentration or liberation.” Yet, without any foundation in samatha, Chan practice cannot truly be carried out.

First of all, just practicing samatha is very challenging. Second, concentration is something that must be trained, and anything that comes from training arises from causes and conditions. When these conditions come together, concentration grows; when they fade, concentration weakens. Awareness, however, is something each of us already possesses. Therefore, once we unlock it, we just need to keep using it and become familiar with it—it

strength can only grow and will not fade.

Furthermore, in the past, some great masters believed that placing too much emphasis on samadhi could hinder the realization of emptiness. This is because the mind that realizes emptiness must be more relaxed, open, and free from contrivance. Excessive training in samadhi can cause the mind to become fixed in a contrived state, making it difficult to return to the original mind. Many non-Buddhist practitioners in ancient India attained the Four Dhyanas and Eight Samadhis, yet were still unable to achieve liberation. That is why Chan Buddhism sets aside samadhi and directly guides practitioners to realize their original mind.

The Three-Stage Mindfulness Meditation we advocate is tailored for modern practitioners. This method, rooted in the Four Foundations of Mindfulness taught by the Buddha in the *Satipatthana Sutta*, cultivates concentration while developing awareness. I believe this is the most direct and practical meditation method the Buddha

has taught, and it is especially effective for people today.

Why has mindfulness become so popular around the world? First, it is relatively easy to put into practice. Second, it can unlock our awareness, and awareness can treat many physical and mental conditions. However, the mindfulness practiced in society often focuses more on the technical aspects and lacks deeper insight. In contrast, Buddhist mindfulness meditation, guided by the insight of emptiness, can help us develop awareness and lead to the awakening and liberation of life itself.

III

THE FOUR KEY ELEMENTS OF VIPASSANA

Vipassana, built upon samatha, emphasizes four key elements: awareness, acceptance, non-judgment, and right view.

1. The Seventh Element: Awareness

Awareness depends on concentration as its foundation; only through concentration can it be unlocked. Therefore, we must recognize that awareness lies at the heart of meditation, and accessing it is the purpose of practicing concentration.

We need to realize the value of unlocking awareness in meditation: awareness is the most direct path to our awakened nature. Therefore, when I guide meditation, I often invite everyone to experience the mind that is clear and aware, because this aware mind is a vital power for both practice and liberation—it is the natural function of awareness itself.

Furthermore, only by unlocking awareness can we transcend the dualistic world. What is our greatest problem? It is that we cannot truly see ourselves. Why can't we see ourselves clearly? Because we live in ignorance—trapped in dualistic thinking and caught in the stream of thought—so we cannot see ourselves clearly. And because we cannot see ourselves clearly, we are unable to step out of our thoughts, and can only remain in a state of unawareness.

Developing awareness means unlocking the inner power of observing inward. With awareness, we can do three things: first, see our thoughts clearly; second, keep

distance from them; and third, with awareness, allow thoughts to dissolve naturally, freeing us from afflictions. As the ancient masters said, “Do not fear the arising of thoughts; fear only that awareness comes too late.” In meditation, our task is simply to remain aware—nothing more.

In the past, the Chan tradition only talked about returning to the original mind. Chan patriarchs gave many insightful teachings that pointed directly to the original mind. However, many people cannot directly realize it without awareness as an essential bridge. As a result, Chan teachings could guide only those with sharp faculties and deep wisdom. Yet the Three-Stage Mindfulness Meditation provides such a bridge. It begins by unlocking awareness at the level of consciousness and then leads us back to the original mind. This level of awareness is something everyone can experience. When we understand it and learn to use it, we can keep distance from thoughts, and dissolve emotions and afflictions. And as the mind becomes clearer and more open, realizing the original

mind will no longer be difficult.

When guiding meditation, I often ask practitioners to see what the mind of awareness looks like—this is a common method in Buddhist practice. For example, Chan teachings include the famous saying “Bring me your mind, and I’ll put it at ease.” And in the *Shurangama Sutra*, Ananda searches for the mind in seven locations. All these point to the same method: directly observing the original mind. Why is this kind of observation so useful? When we observe, what is the mind that is observing? It is the mind of awareness. As we observe, we are unlocking this mind of awareness; when we observe thoughts through awareness, we naturally realize they are empty in nature. Then we can experience what the Chan teaching describes as “seeking the mind, yet finding it unattainable.” Thus, we first cultivate awareness and then unlock our awakened nature; this approach is both skillful and effective. Therefore, in mindfulness practice, we should focus on cultivating awareness.

Then we learn to move from awareness to letting go of awareness, from having an object of attention to having no object of attention, from contrivance to non-contrivance, from doing to non-doing, and from contrived practice to uncontrived practice. In fact, true practice requires no deliberate effort. When we become somewhat familiar with our original mind and can abide in it, practice instead becomes easier. We need not do anything—we simply abide there. The original mind we seek to experience has always been present, neither increasing nor decreasing, and it does not require you to do anything. Thus, awareness itself is a skillful means leading toward the awakened nature.

From intermediate to advanced meditation practice, the focus shifts from using awareness to letting it go. Letting go of awareness does not mean that there is no awareness; rather, it means experiencing the awareness that is free from any fabrication or effort. What kind of awareness do we need to let go of? It is the contrived, intentional awareness. And what kind of awareness do we need to

realize? It is the uncontrived, ever-present awareness; it is the clear mind that is more open, vast, formless, and effortless. This mind is not far from any of us. When we follow a step-by-step path of meditation, reaching the goal is not as difficult as we imagine.

2. The Eighth Element: Acceptance

In both daily life and meditation, we may face various challenges; learning how to accept them is vital for our cultivation. Generally speaking, we cling to what we like and resist what we dislike. When we fail to accept, we create dualistic opposition and fall into greed, aversion, and ignorance.

How do we learn acceptance? It is cultivated through meditation. During meditation, we face various thoughts and mental images. Yet many people wish to have no delusive thoughts. When wandering thoughts arise, they find it difficult not only to accept these thoughts, but also to accept themselves. Because they fail to accept, even

more delusive thoughts arise.

In fact, all thoughts and images are but clouds drifting across the sky of the mind, just as the saying goes, “All things are but passing clouds.” When white clouds appear, they bring their own beauty; when dark clouds come, they may bring a refreshing rain—there is also beauty in them. Thus, in meditation, acceptance means staying aware of whatever thoughts or images arise, without following or resisting them.

To practice acceptance, we need the right views. Ordinary people are accustomed to taking their thoughts and the objects they encounter as real, so their minds are easily carried away. But we realize that all thoughts and the objects they encounter are simply images appearing in the sky of the mind. And everything we see and hear is only an image. Just as the *Diamond Sutra* says, “All conditioned phenomena are like dreams, illusions, bubbles, and shadows,” we stop taking our thoughts and the objects we encounter as so real. So it becomes much easier to accept

whatever arises within us and around us.

When we really can't accept something, even meditation can feel like sitting on pins and needles. What can we do then? We have another method, the Eight Steps and Three Types of Meditation. We can try to reflect on what we cannot accept with Buddhist insight. Some people, during meditation, even get caught in inner knots that have been unresolved for decades, with all kinds of emotions entangling them without end, unable to let them go. In such moments, we can use the Eight-Three Method to reflect on them in accordance with the Buddhist insight, such as the principle of dependent origination. We keep reflecting until these inner knots are gradually untied.

Many practitioners have shared their stories of studying Buddhism. For example, some were deeply hurt by their family members in childhood and suffered for decades. Through studying Buddhism, they came to understand their experiences in a new light, and untied the inner knots. Not only were past resentments dissolved, but they

reconciled and became as close as before. Such stories are countless. This shows that when we re-examine our experiences with Buddhist wisdom, and realize they're not as important as we once believed, they no longer disturb our meditation as much.

We need to learn to accept things as they are. This acceptance has two levels. The first is acceptance through understanding. The second is abiding in awareness, which allows acceptance to arise naturally. Awareness helps our mind keep distance from the things we encounter and the emotions we feel. As we become used to keeping a distance from our emotions and thoughts, it becomes easier to face them again. As long as we abide in awareness, their influences naturally fade.

Therefore, learning acceptance through meditation is not only about understanding this insight, but also about accepting things as they are through awareness. When we face different situations while abiding in awareness, we are able to accept them more easily.

3. The Ninth Element: Non-Judgment

Practicing non-judgment is actually a wise approach. Many modern people, influenced by Western education, value individuality and freedom. They feel that they should always have their own views about everything. So, when something happens, they often tend to criticize first, thinking it makes them look smart.

Buddhist practice does not completely avoid judgment. In practice, the mind works at two levels. One is the discriminative mind, which uses rational thinking. The other is the non-discriminative mind, which operates through pure intuition beyond reasoning. The Eight-Three Method teaches us to make good use of the discriminative mind—to apply rationality properly. By studying and reflecting on the teachings, we establish the right view. With the right view, we can re-examine all phenomena, and gain wisdom to see and judge things as they truly are. Therefore, the Eight-Three Method encourages us to make good use of rationality and judgment. This

shows that Buddhist practice does not avoid rationality or judgment. People make judgments to express their individuality, while Buddhist judgment is based on the right view and guided by wisdom. It places a higher demand on how we use rationality.

Why does mindfulness meditation emphasize non-judgment? Because once we judge, we enter the system of the discriminative mind. It is important to note, however, that non-judgment does not necessarily mean we have gone beyond the discriminative mind. There are many reasons for not judging—such as not wanting to judge, not paying attention, or simply being unable to judge. In mindfulness practice, non-judgment refers to the state that arises when the mind abides in awareness.

There are two ways we perceive things: one is through the discriminative mind, and the other is through awareness. These are two different ways of using the mind. Buddhist practice is simple in one way, yet not so simple in another. Why is it simple? Because practice is about changing the

habitual way we use our mind. Why is it not so simple? Because changing that habit is not easy.

Without practice, our mind tends to chase after external things. This activates the discriminative mind, judging whether something is good or bad, beneficial or harmful. However, meditation teaches us to use awareness instead. Whatever thoughts or mental images arise, we simply remain aware of them, like a clear mirror reflecting everything in the present moment. When we face our thoughts and mental images with awareness, we do not judge them. If we judge them, we will fall into the system of discriminative mind. If we do not enter judgment but abide in awareness, we enter the level of awareness within the mind. From this awareness, we can return to our true mind and awakened nature. Without practice, we keep chasing after external things; with practice, we unlock the awareness. These are two completely different ways of using the mind.

Should we never judge or compare? Not necessarily. If

we are more familiar with the wisdom of emptiness, our empty and clear mind grows stronger. In this case, even if we judge and compare, we can still abide in the awareness. Why do we emphasize not judging? Because in the early stages of meditation, awareness is not yet strong or stable. Once judgment arises, the mind slips back into discriminative mode, and awareness is lost. That is why the *Xinxin Ming (Faith in Mind)* says, “The supreme Way is not difficult; it only dislikes picking and choosing.” That is, realizing the great Way is not hard. As long as we do not enter the discriminative mind, we can naturally experience the original mind, where emptiness and clarity are non-dual.

Especially in the early stages of meditation, when we are still developing awareness, we should rely on awareness, rather than on discrimination. As our awareness grows stronger and we become more familiar with this clear mind, we can reach a more advanced stage of practice. At that stage, we can discern all phenomena while remaining unmoved in the ultimate truth, or make distinctions all day long while realizing their empty nature. In other

words, we can discriminate things while abiding in non-discriminative awareness. This represents a higher level of meditation practice. So, the use of discrimination in meditation is not fixed. Many people wonder why Buddhism sometimes teaches discrimination and at other times non-discrimination. In fact, these teachings address different stages of meditative practice, offering guidance tailored to each practitioner's faculties.

When we learn to unlock and cultivate awareness through meditation, learning not to judge is an essential part of the practice. What we cultivate is not mere non-judgement, but the ability to abide in awareness so that judgement naturally falls away. Mere non-judgement may come from other reasons, such as not knowing how to judge or simply lacking interest. That is a different matter. In mindfulness meditation, the focus is on abiding in awareness and learning to use awareness rather than judgement. When we keep practicing awareness, becoming familiar with it until it becomes our habit, then even when judgement arises, it no longer disturbs our mindfulness practice.

4. The Tenth Element: Right View

The right view is the correct understanding of the world and of life. Where does the right view come from? It arises through studying and reflecting on the teachings, as well as through practicing the Eight-Three Method. Only with the right view can we awaken true wisdom.

In developing the right view, it is especially important to see things through the principle of dependent origination. Just as modern physics is built on theories such as quantum mechanics, general relativity, special relativity, and other such theories, Buddhism teaches the principle of dependent origination—seeing that all phenomena arise from conditions. We can say that this principle embodies Buddhism's true understanding of the phenomenal world, the universe, and human life.

After studying Buddhism, many people gain profound teachings, yet fail to grasp the most fundamental right view of dependent origination when understanding

others or handling daily problems. Instead, they continue to approach problems from a self-centered perspective, driven by strong self-attachment and habitual likes and dislikes. In fact, true Buddhist practice means learning to interact with others and handle matters through the understanding of dependent origination. When we cultivate this way of thinking, we develop the right view—seeing impermanence, no-self, and that all things are empty in nature—for these insights all arise from understanding dependent origination.

How can we apply the right view during meditation? When thoughts or mental images arise, if we bring in the right view of no-self, we can observe: “A thought is just a thought—it is not the true self. An image is just an image—it is not the true self. Both thoughts and images have nothing to do with the true self.” However, ordinary people have a strong sense of self; whether in thinking or acting, they are guided by this self-centered feeling. If we do not know how to apply the right view in meditation, when a thought arises, most people follow

it unconsciously and become lost in it. But when the right view guides our meditation, we can clearly perceive bodily sensations, the flow of the breath, and the arising and passing of thoughts—seeing that all of them arise and cease through conditions. They are impermanent, constantly changing, and without a fixed self. All these thoughts and images are not the true self. Ultimately, we come to see that body, feelings, mind, and dharmas are, in their true nature, empty.

Why does Chan Buddhism say, “seeking the mind, yet finding it unattainable?” Because the nature of mind is emptiness. If a thought were truly solid and real, how could it vanish completely when observed? Without the observation guided by the right view, even a single thought can grow overwhelming—some are so powerful that they can dominate our entire life for decades. When observation is guided by the right view, we can see through a thought the instant it arises and directly realize the empty nature of the mind.

So, meditation is not about deliberately getting rid of thoughts. Every thought is empty in nature—just as every wave is, in essence, nothing but water. We also don't need to judge our thoughts, or divide them into “good” and “bad.” The moment we label a thought as “good,” we've added another “good” thought; when we see a thought as “bad,” we've created another “bad” one. In this way, our mind keeps producing all kinds of ideas—good and bad. Without noticing, these ideas create more delusive thoughts, and we start clinging to them. The true practice of meditation is to let go of all mental labels, and maintain observation guided by the right view. When we do this, all thoughts naturally return to the ocean of our awakened nature.

Chan Buddhism teaches Buddha-nature and emphasizes seeing one's true nature. Through this practice, we come to experience a mind that is clear and vast—a mind embodying both clarity and emptiness. The very nature of awareness is awakened nature: it knows all things clearly and completely, and is as vast as the void. This

understanding reflects the teaching of the Tathagatagarbha: all sentient beings inherently possess Buddha-nature.

Buddhist practice serves two purposes. On the one hand, it helps us see clearly the dualistic world, understanding that this world is dependently arising and illusory, so that we are no longer trapped in the dualistic opposition. On the other hand, it guides us to realize our original mind—the non-dual mind of clarity and emptiness. These different Buddhist insights reflect different levels of understanding of life. Some are meant to help us break through the fog of delusion, while others lead us directly to realize our true mind. When we start to practice meditation, we can use the right views of impermanence and no-self: seeing through the phenomenal world, and stepping beyond dualistic thinking. We come to realize that thoughts arise and cease through conditions, have no fixed self, and are empty in their very nature. As our awareness expands, we naturally return to the original mind. This path of practice is clear and not as complicated as we may imagine.

IV

CONCLUSION

Today we discussed the ten elements of mindfulness meditation. Everyone should first understand them completely, clearly, and accurately. It is important to know which are foundational elements, which are core elements, and which are applied to different situations during meditation. Once we understand them, we must apply them well in our mindfulness practice.

In the future, we will develop standardized self-assessment guides based on these ten elements for beginner, intermediate, and advanced levels of meditation. Meditation, once thought to be abstract, will no longer

seem so abstract.

In addition, for the foundational part of meditation, I have recently invited experienced yoga-teaching volunteers to integrate mindfulness practice into the Eight Mindful Exercises for Lotus Posture and Seven Mindful Exercises for Breathing. These have been produced as audio and video materials to help everyone better regulate the body and breath, thereby supporting mindfulness meditation. When we have established a solid foundation in mindfulness practice, use the right way of applying the mind, and make good use of the self-assessment checklist for the ten elements of beginner-level mindfulness meditation, mindfulness meditation will naturally become easier.